Becoming – A Collection

By Jonathan Green, Roger Bonair-Agard and John Roedel

Becoming and Unbecoming by Jonathan Green

Each day I want to be the best version of myself
and then I fail, and fall flat on my face,
chipping two teeth and busting my lip and nose
only to realize that I can try again tomorrow

I am constantly becoming and unbecoming my best self
and it gets pretty tiring trying to figure out which is which
so I drink some tea and look deep into the mirror
so I can decide which version of myself I am today

And the second I realize who is staring back at me
I start to become a new version of that person
a constant realization that I am both enough and not
    enough
all at the same time, with this same face, this same brain

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How can I become someone while unbecoming someone
    else
when I don't even know which one was objectively better
or more so, which one I even liked being from inside of
    these eyes
looking at a moving target of myself and who I want to be?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: ***Jonathan Green***
Website: ***https://medium.com/isolation/becoming-and-unbecoming-c6dae66b3940***
ISBN: ***N/A***
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INTRODUCTION

So many of us go through life with our stories hidden, feeling ashamed that we haven't lived up to some self- or society- imposed ideal . . . But becoming doesn't have an end game. Becoming is a life-long process.

The Skin Horse explains in the Velveteen Rabbit by Margery Williams: "You become. It takes a long time. That's why it doesn't happen often to people who break easily, or have sharp edges, or who have to be carefully kept. . . You become."

Becoming – A Collection containing Becoming and Unbecoming by Jonathan Green, Naming and Other Christian Things by Roger Bonair-Agard and Hey God. Hey John by John Roedel.

Naming and Other Christian Things by Roger Bonair-Agard

(Pg 196-197)

At 31 I finally learn that Lena is short for Magdalene
    one of those enigmas of biblical lore
whore found religion
I have often questioned her motives -- this love of Jesus
    Christ
this holy supplication to the Son of Man
And I think about Lena my grandmother
    great big woman, skin of ashy obsidian
hair whitened with the burden of conviction
and I wonder about this business of weeping and
    foot washing;
    but I can only remember her iron hand and
    rigid schedules
her admonition on catching me daydreaming on
    the outhouse roof

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- Get down off that thing boy
- You have your book to study
- What kind of man do you expect to become?!

I recall her jacking up of my equally stern
    grandfather
reminding him of the folly
of any repeated attempts to hit her
    Never does Mary Magdalene come to mind
    not in the helpless "weeping for the crucified" way
    not in the convenient Catholic depictions
of feminine frailty of morals and spirit
    I know of a Magdalene with fight
more Joan of Arc than Maid Marion
more Sojourner Truth than damsel in distress
    and I want to tell the withering two-
        dimensional ghost
couched and crumpled at the foot of the cross

- Get up and fight woman!
- Wake up and live if you love him!
- Jack up the Pontius Pilate and refuse
  surrender

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At 4 I was beaten for disrespect of my
grandfather
at 8 because I was satisfied with only a 75 in
Math --
because she knew having fought battles based
purely on conviction
that she was preparing a man for the holiest of
crucifixions
there would be no washing of feet here
no flimsy eruption of tears
only the austerity of a warrior
and a Puritan insistence on perfection and effort
the creases through her aged jowls softening
only when she thought I need to eat to get
strong

- Son yuh lookin thin; come and get
some food

a name orients one to his universe the Lakotas
believed
so a change in a name meant a chance for
improvement

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for the child who was not doing well
so having learned the root of my
grandmother's name
I cannot summon the sympathy for Mary Magdalene
cannot help her weep tears of distress
only wish I could retroactivate a name change for her
show her my grandmother carrying 30lb sacks of coffee
dragging her swollen leg behind her
rising from her deathbed to fight her daughter's battles

One day if I am worthy of her expectations
I will become a man worth crucifying
and all her beatings
her lessons
her Puritanism and super-human strength
will have taught me
that surrender is not an option

On that day I expect to see
standing at the foot of whatever urban cross they fashion
all five-foot-ten of Lena
pointing one huge gnarled finger at me

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the shining authority of her eyes
coming from the black forest of her flesh
the white electricity of her hair
lips trembling in rage

- Get down off that thing boy and fight!
- What kind of man do you intend to become?!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Roger Bonair-Agard
Book: The Spoken Word Revolution (Pg 196-197)
ISBN: 978-0321328953
Publisher: Longman
Date (Month/Year): 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier (This poem only)

Hey God, Hey John by John Roedel

Me: Hey God.

God: Hello . . .

Me: I'm falling apart. Can you put me back together?

God: I would rather not.

Me: Why?

God: Because you aren't a puzzle.

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Me: What about all of the pieces of my life that are falling down onto the ground?

God: Let them stay there for a while. They fell off for a reason. Take some time and decide if you need any of those pieces back.

Me: You don't understand! I'm breaking down!

God: No - you don't understand. You are breaking through. What you are feeling are just growing pains. You are shedding the things and the people in your life that are holding you back. You aren't falling apart. You are falling into place. Relax. Take some deep breaths and allow those things you don't need anymore to fall off of you. Quit holding onto the pieces that don't fit you anymore. Let them fall off. Let them go.

Me: Once I start doing that, what will be left of me?

God: Only the very best pieces of you.

Me: I'm scared of changing.

God: I keep telling you - YOU AREN'T CHANGING!! YOU ARE BECOMING!

Me: Becoming who?

God: Becoming who I created you to be! A person of light and love and charity and hope and courage and joy

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and mercy and grace and compassion. I made you for more than the shallow pieces you have decided to adorn yourself with that you cling to with such greed and fear. Let those things fall off of you. I love you! Don't change! ... Become! Become! Become who I made you to be. I'm going to keep telling you this until you remember it.

Me: There goes another piece.

God: Yep. Let it be.

Me: So . . . I'm not broken?

God: Of course Not! - but you are breaking like the dawn. It's a new day. Become!!!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: John Roedel
Book: 2023 Poetry Wall Calendar
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: John Roedel
Date (Month/Year): 2022

Can be Purchased at https://johnroedel.square.site

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